

Dice loaded against online gambling

It is a classic cat-and-mouse game. US prosecutors spend a lot of time busting online gambling sites. But US law holds online gambling illegal only within the US. Most gambling sites are located outside US territory (Costa Rica, etc).

So, American law enforcers are doing the next best thing—targeting those US companies that do business with such sites by providing advertising and other services.

Several individuals and



companies who have worked with Internet casinos have been issued legal notices. Along with pornography and shopping, gambling is the Internet's biggest moneyspinner. So, we guess it is back to the good old days of heading to Las Vegas to bask in the hospitality of Caesar's Palace.

snapshot

In last quarter of **2003**, total **Linux servers** shipments were about **2,50,000** a growth of over **53** per cent over last year

Source: IDC

China's search engines take on Google

Ladies and Gentlemen, welcome to the bout that decides the undisputed heavyweight search engine championship of China. We have three contenders for the championship belt. Join your hands for Baidu.com, Zhongsou.com and the interestingly named Yahoo subsidiary, 3721.com in the Red corner.

And in the Blue Corner, we have the current undisputed search engine champion of the world, Google.com, who entered China some time back to corner a piece of the US\$ 100 million market.

The bout has begun well, with all the Nasdaq-listed Chinese sites becoming profitable, thanks to sponsored links at the top of the search results.

But will Google sit back and relax? No siree, the champion fought back in February launching a Chinese language ad service. But 3721.com founder Zhou Hongyi who sold his company to Yahoo for US\$ 120 million has said a few

sweet words about Google recently. We quote him verbatim: "My job in China is to kick Google's ass."

Hongyi is all ready to take on Google. With a Net penetration of 80 million users and expected market size to be US\$ 200 million by 2006, Hongyi

sees nothing but a brutal fight for the top spot. He has

already scored the first jab on Google's chin:

His site's database of searchable sites is already at 150 million.

His partner in the tag-team bout is Robin Li, founder of Baidu, who claimed a searchable index size of 220 million. But chances are that Google may buy over Baidu.

Zhongsou, meanwhile, has a database of 280 million.

With this, ladies and gentlemen, we come to the end of Round One of the heavyweight search engine championship in China. Right now, the honours have been shared. See you soon in Round Two.



Universally digital

IBM's legendary chairman Tom Watson used to have a board behind his desk. On the board were written five letters in large type: THINK. Universal Music International (UMI) has added three letters to that, and come up with THINK BIG.

UMI has announced that it has finished digitising three lakh songs from the 25,000-odd albums in its catalogue, amounting to 20 Terabytes.

UMI tells us that each CD worth of music has been stored as a disc image and not as individual tracks, with the Universal Packaging Code (UPC) and International Standard Recording Code (ISRC) codes intact.

Now, distributors can demand a format and a bitrate of their choice for online delivery. As of now, Europe, where UMI is located, has only one legal download service—O2.



Spam

Service, no smiles

Office XP users who install the recently released Office XP Service Pack 3 will find that at least two anti-spam products, Sunbelt Software's IHateSpam and Cloudmark's SpamNet are hampered by SP3.

Users of these products who have updated Office XP will get warnings that a program is trying to access the e-mail addresses stored in Outlook and that this could be a virus, but no further details.

IHateSpam users can find a patch on the Web site that addresses this issue, but users of SpamNet will have to wait as Cloudmark and Microsoft work towards releasing a patch.

Clash of the titans

Even as spam reaches ridiculous proportions, four major US ISPs have teamed up to sue over 220 alleged spammers. AOL, Earthlink, Yahoo and Microsoft have initiated litigation in several US states against spammers.

The move has seen widespread support from lawmakers in the US, who have praised the initiative. The lawsuits are the first to be filed under a new US anti-spam law that is called CAN-SPAM.

snapshot

IBM has the **largest** server market share in **Asia Pacific** region—**37.4** per cent in 2003, based on revenue

Source: Gartner